

Franciscan Institute Publications

An Unexplored Influence on the "Epistola ad fideles" of Francis of Assisi: The "Epistola universis Christi fidelibus" of Joachim of Fiore

Author(s): MICHAEL F. CUSATO

Source: *Franciscan Studies*, Vol. 61 (2003), pp. 253-278

Published by: [Franciscan Institute Publications](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41975316>

Accessed: 12-12-2015 18:07 UTC

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.



Franciscan Institute Publications is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Franciscan Studies*.

<http://www.jstor.org>

An Unexplored Influence on the *Epistola ad fideles* of Francis of Assisi: The *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus* of Joachim of Fiore

During the summer of 1220, shaken by news from Italy of a variety of troubles brewing within the Order of Friars Minor, Francis of Assisi left the Holy Land – where he had gone to oppose the Fifth Crusade the previous year¹ – in order to return home to Italy.² He was accompanied on this journey by most, if not all, of the friars who had been with him in the East: among them, Elias of Cortona,³ Peter of Catanio,⁴ Stephen of Narni,⁵ Illuminato⁶ and Caesar of Speyer.⁷

¹Historians have long puzzled over whether Francis actively opposed the crusade or whether his motivations for going to the Holy Land and Egypt were more spiritual in nature (e.g., in pursuit of martyrdom). Scholars have almost universally tended to come down on the latter side of the question. Indeed, a reading of the hagiographical sources, notably 1 and 2 Celano and Bonaventure's *Legenda maior*, can give such an impression. This is not totally unexpected since these texts, by definition, attempt to present the sainted figure as someone in full conformity with the *vita Christi*, even to the point of embracing the cross of his own death. Nevertheless, a case has convincingly been made, in my view, favoring the position that Francis went to Egypt to explicitly oppose the crusade most notably in a brief article by James Powell (cf. "Francesco d'Assisi e la quinta crociata. Una missione di pace," *Schede medievali*, 4 [1983]: 68-77). A similar argument has been made more recently by Jan Hoebrechts, *Francis and Islam* (Quincy, Illinois: Franciscan Press, 1997) who is familiar with Powell's analysis. The importance of Francis's opposition to the crusade for this article will become apparent later on.

²The exact chronology of these events is difficult to determine with precision. The best guess is that at least some of the troubles in Italy were occasioned by certain actions taken at a chapter held in Assisi in May 1220 by the two vicars whom Francis had left in charge of the fraternity, Gregory of Naples and Matthew of Narni (cf. *Chronica Fratris Jordani*, c. 11, ed. H. Boehmer, Collection d'Études et de Documents, 6 [Paris: Fischbacher, 1908], 9-10).

³Minister of the province of Syria since 1217.

⁴By some accounts, the second companion of Francis (cf. AP 10 and 3Soc 28). Arnaldo Fortini (*Nuova vita*, II, 276-280) contends that the most probable identity of this friar is Peter Catanii (or Peter of Catanio) since affiliated with the family of Catanio of Guiduccio. Although Fortini – and others – have contended that Peter may have been a canon of the Church of San Rufino prior to joining the minorite movement, Jordan (c. 11, 9) claims that he had been trained in civil law. The latter datum appears more consistent with the testimony found in the other sources.

⁵Bearer of the disturbing news from Italy (cf. *Chronica Fratris Jordani*, c. 1211-12). Jordan does not mention the name of the friar courier. Boehmer, editor of Jordan's chronicle, states (page 12, n. 3) that the 16th century Franciscan chronicler, Jan

Disembarking in the vicinity of Venice and after taking care of a number of issues en route to Assisi, Francis called an Emergency Chapter of the whole Order at the Portiuncula in late September, 1220.⁸ It was here at this Chapter that, burdened by increasingly painful physical maladies and discouraged at seeing the direction of the fraternity slipping from his hands, Francis resigned his position as “minister and servant of all the friars,” handing the reins of the Order to Peter of Catanio.⁹

Although he had resigned as minister general of the friars, giving up official authority over the movement he had fostered since 1208, Francis nonetheless retained for himself a kind of moral or charismatic authority, endeavoring, according to the literature of the companions, to remain an exemplar for and salutary influence upon the friars.¹⁰ Indeed, in the six years of life which yet remained to him, with his mobility increasingly curtailed, the single most effective way that he continued to exert a formative influence on the friars – and others associated in some manner with his movement – would be through the written word. And the first writing that he will have penned probably not long after his resignation – indeed the first writing that he will have produced after the *Regula non bullata* – is the so-called “*Epistola ad fideles*”: the *Letter to All the Faithful*.¹¹

Komorowski, identified this lay friar as Stephen of Narni. It seems likely that the same identification made by Wadding (*Annales Minorum*, Vol. 1 [Quaracchi: Editiones Collegii S. Bonaventurae, 1931], 368) is dependent upon this latter source, though not explicitly cited as such.

⁶His companion in the tent of the sultan, Malek al-Kamil (cf. LM IX, 8).

⁷A crusade preacher of some repute who had entered the Franciscan fraternity in the Holy Land thanks to the preaching of Brother Elias.

⁸A time normally reserved for provincial chapters. I essentially agree with the reconstruction of the return route of Francis's party and the dating of this chapter to Michaelmas 1220 as proposed by J. Moorman, *A History of the Franciscan Order from its Origins to the Year 1517* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1968), 50-51.

⁹2Cel 143.

¹⁰Cf. AC 106.

¹¹I am opting to refer to this text under its more traditional designation, *Epistola ad fideles*. Indeed, this is the title preferred by Kajetan Esser in his critical edition of the *opuscula* of Francis: *Die Opuscula des hl. Franziskus von Assisi. Neue textkritische Edition*, Spicilegium Bonaventurianum, 13 (Grottaferrata: Editiones Collegii S. Bonaventurae ad Claras Aquas, 1976), 176-215. In his so-called *editio minor* (*Opuscula sancti patris Francisci Assisiensis*, Bibliotheca Franciscana Ascetica Medii Aevi 12 [Grottaferrata: Editiones Collegii S. Bonaventurae ad Claras Aquas, 1978], 113-128), Esser uses the same

The Basic Problematic

This famous letter, which exists in two rather different versions – let me refer to them for the moment as the longer version and the shorter version – has posed numerous problems for historians of the Franciscan movement, particularly with regard to the relationship between the two obviously related documents.¹² Not a few historians have attempted to address the various problems associated with these two texts, among them several of the most eminent franciscanists of the latter part of the twentieth century including Kajetan Esser,¹³ David Flood,¹⁴ Théophile Desbonnets¹⁵ and Enrico Menestò.¹⁶ Indeed, as Margaret Carney has recently reminded us,¹⁷ there is still no agreement about the precise title of these texts.¹⁸ But perhaps the mostly thorny

appellation. Moreover, the general title *Epistola ad fideles* is used to refer to two different, if related, texts – an anomaly I shall address at the conclusion of this article.

¹² In this, I am following the distinction employed by Esser who refers to the shorter version as the *Epistola ad fideles (Recensio prior)* [EpFid I] and the longer version as the *Epistola ad fideles (Recensio posterior)* [EpFid II]. Moreover, he gives the shorter version [EpFidI] a further descriptive title, calling it an *Exhortatio ad fratres et sorores de poenitentia*.

¹³K. Esser, “La lettera di san Francesco ai fedeli,” *L’Ordine della penitenza di san Francesco d’Assisi nel secolo XIII*, ed. O. Schmucki (Rome: 1973), 65–78.

¹⁴D. Flood, “The Commonitorium,” *Haversack*, Vol. III, no. 1 (1979): 20–23; Vol. III, no. 2 (1979): 20–23; Vol III, no. 3 (1980): 21–23; Vol. III, no. 4 (1980): 20–24; Vol. III, no. 5 (1980): 19–24; Vol. III, no. 6 (1980): 21–23.

¹⁵T. Desbonnets, “La lettre à tous les fidèles de François d’Assise,” *I frati minori e il Terzo Ordine: problemi e discussioni storiografiche*. Convegni del Centro di Studi sulla spiritualità medievale, 23 (Todi: Accademia Tudertina, 1985), 53–76.

¹⁶E. Menestò, “Per una rilettura della *Epistola ad fideles* di san Francesco d’Assisi,” *Analecta T.O.R.* 24 (1998): 9–23 (Engl. version: *Greyfriars Review*, 14 [2000]: 97–110).

¹⁷A problem nicely surveyed by Margaret Carney in a forthcoming article to be published by New City Press in a volume commemorating the conclusion of the *Early Documents* project.

¹⁸This is a problem endemic to not a few medieval documents. Frequently bearing no official or formal titles, it is left to compilers in later generations to distinguish such texts from others through the use of more descriptive, identifying titles. In the case of this text, according to Esser (*Die Opuscula*, 188), the earliest designation given to it – in Assisi MS 338 (mid-13th cent.), Munich Latin MS 11354 (15th cent.) and Madrid MS 1258 (16th cent.) – was that of a “*commonitorium et exhortatorium*” (viz. *Incipit opusculum venerabilis patris nostri sancti Francisci commonitorium et exhortatorium*). Other families of manuscripts, however, offer a wide variety of designations derived from a description of the actual content or audience of the letter. Esser’s preferred choice of titles seems to have been based on this latter approach. For in a series of manuscripts that he labelled family “c” in his *Editio minor* (114) – Ax, B1, BU, Ko, Lb, OB, SF, V1 – one finds the following description: “*Incipit epistola beati Francisci missa universis christianis. In nomine Domini patris et filii et spiritus sancti. Amen. Admonitorium et exhortatorium.*” This, in my view,

and fundamental question of all is the chronological question: which of the two versions was written first? And an answer to this question is related to two others: to whom and for what purpose was each of them written? I would like to revisit these questions. To do so, it may be helpful to lay out three assumptions with which I begin this exploration (and hope to demonstrate shortly):

- First (and contrary both to Esser as well as the editors of the recently completed multi-volume *Francis of Assisi: Early Documents*),¹⁹ I would contend that the longer version of the *Letter* was in fact written first and that it was drafted sometime shortly after Francis's resignation – that is, either in late 1220 or early 1221;²⁰
- Second, it is my belief that the idea and model for this *Epistola ad fideles* was an earlier *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus* written by Joachim of Fiore; and
- Third, that it was Caesar of Speyer who brought this document to Francis's attention either in the Holy Land in 1219 or, more probably, during the months prior to or shortly after the Emergency Chapter of September, 1220.

comes closest to describing the audience for whom the letter was intended. In his above-cited series of articles, David Flood (cf. *Haversack*, Vol. III, no. 1, [1979], 21-22), however, prefers the earliest chronological designation found in Assisi MS 338 (*commonitorium*), asserting that the term signals that the letter is a reminder of a message previously announced to the movement (viz., in the *Early Rule*). This seemingly persuasive argument is weakened, in my view, by two considerations. First, the term *commonitorium*, far from necessarily referring the reader back to a previous document, is in fact a fairly generic term referring to any kind of tract of religious inspiration or content (cf. J.F. Niermeyer, *Mediae latinitatis lexicon minus* [Leiden: E.J.Brill, 1984], 219, definition 2). Second, the audience of the longer version of the *epistola* is actually much wider than those attached to the minorite movement. Indeed, it is addressed to *universis christianis*: the *fidelibus* of the whole Christian society, including those already within the Franciscan movement. Hence, Esser's preference for the title *Epistola ad fideles*.

¹⁹*Francis of Assisi: Early Documents, Vol. I: The Saint*, eds. R. Armstrong, W. Hellmann and W. Short (New York: New City Press, 1999), 41-51. The editors, following but adapting Esser, use the following designations for the two documents: "Earlier Exhortation to the Brothers and Sisters of Penance (The First Version of the Letter to the Faithful) (1209-1215)" [41-44]; and "Later Admonition and Exhortation to the Brothers and Sisters of Penance (Second Version of the Letter to the Faithful) (1220?)" [45-51].

²⁰In other words, in my view, the EpFidII (the longer version) pre-dates the EpFid I (the shorter version). Indeed, the shorter version is *dependent upon* the longer version.

Given the pivotal role played by this latter figure, allow me then to start my exploration with a word about Caesar.

Caesar of Speyer

By far the most extensive evidence that we have about the person and activities of Caesar of Speyer relevant to this discussion comes from the *Chronicle* of Jordan of Giano.²¹ Jordan knew Caesar rather well, having accompanied him northward with ninety other friars to create a new province in Germany after the General Chapter of May 1221.²² It is Jordan who tells us about Caesar's entry into the fraternity in the Holy Land.²³ And, perhaps most critically for us, it is also Jordan who tells us about his previous theological training and subsequent work with Francis to fill out the text of the *Regula non bullata* with passages from the Scriptures, especially the Gospels.²⁴ This commonly-known contribution of Caesar, however, illustrates a deeper point: namely, that Caesar enjoyed a collaborative relationship with Francis in the drafting of a number of texts that date from this same period. Indeed, it is my contention that Francis entrusted such tasks to Caesar not merely because of the latter's exegetical acumen but, more importantly, because the two men shared a common vision of minorite life. This rapport helps to explain not only the trust Francis placed in his abilities but also the depth of fraternal sentiment between the two men conveyed in the *Letter to a Minister* – that minister being Caesar in Germany – to say nothing of the sense of betrayal and outrage at the direction taken by the Order after the death of Francis expressed by Caesar himself as author of the *Sacrum commercium*.²⁵

²¹*Chronica Fratris Jordani*, cc. 17-31, 17-32, passim. The *Liber chronicarum sive tribulationum Ordinis minorum* of Angelo Clareno also contains extremely important information about Caesar, though not pertinent to this discussion.

²²*Chronica Fratris Jordani*, c. 18, 19-21.

²³*Chronica Fratris Jordani*, cc. 9 and 14, 7-8 and 13-15.

²⁴*Chronica Fratris Jordani*, c. 15, 15: "Et videns beatus Franciscus fratrem Cesarium sacris litteris eruditum ipsi commisit, ut regulam, quam ipse simplicibus verbis conceperat, verbis evangelii adornaret. Quod et facit."

²⁵I have argued both of these contentions in my doctoral dissertation, *La renonciation au pouvoir chez les Frères Mineurs au 13e siècle*, chapters 1 and 2 (PhD Diss. Université de Paris IV-Sorbonne, 1991) which is being prepared for publication in English. In the meantime, for an overview of these ideas, one can consult M. Cusato, "Talking about

This precious information leads me to add a fourth assumption to my previous three: namely, that during this period – from September, 1220 until his departure for Germany in the fall of 1221 as minister provincial²⁶ – Caesar collaborated with Francis on at least four texts that today bear the name of Francis: the *Regula non bullata*, chapter 22; the *Regula non bullata*, chapter 23; *Admonition* 1; and this longer version of the *Epistola ad fideles* from which the three other texts are all tributary. Although space does not permit a close textual examination of any these writings,²⁷ let me make several general observations about these four texts:

- First, they all bear witness to a rather extraordinary and nuanced knowledge of the Scriptures;
- Second, they are, in some instances, quite richly theological in nature; and
- Third, their literary style is significantly different from Francis's own style – a difference that is easily recognizable within several of these very same documents.

Hence, my determination to see these texts as collaborative efforts.²⁸ And these points are perhaps no more clearly evident than in the *Letter to the Faithful*.

Ourselves: The Shift in Franciscan Writing from Hagiography to History (1235-1247)," *Franciscan Studies* 58 (2000): 42-53.

²⁶Jordan notes (c. 19, 24) that, after the Chapter of 1221, Caesar sent the friars ahead to northern Italy without him "for about three months" ("Ipse vero in valle Spoletana moram fecit fere per tres menses") at which time he will have joined up with the group to begin the crossing of the Alps into Germanic lands. Although the chronicler states that the delay was due to the fact that Caesar was reluctant to part company with Francis and the brothers, one might speculate that a more cogent reason for the delay was that the two men had several collaborative literary projects that they needed to complete before Caesar could head northwards. Most critically would have been the expansion of the *Regula non bullata*, parts of which, I contend, were based on material contained in the long version of the *Epistola ad fideles*.

²⁷I hope to publish a companion article in which these texts are examined much more carefully to show the repetition of certain key passages and themes in these various documents. What is interesting is that once Caesar will have left for Germany, the texts that Francis wrote after this time – particularly the letters and admonitions – will not give evidence of the same textual similarities that are evident between the other four writings dated between 1220-1221. How could they? Caesar was now gone.

²⁸Such collaborative ventures were not uncommon to Caesar. In an article soon to be published in a volume of essays celebrating the *Early Documents* project ("*Commercium*:"

Caesar and Joachim

Before turning to the letter itself, however, a little more background is still needed to fill out the picture. Jordan of Giano informs us that Caesar was “a German born in Speyer and a subdeacon” who had been “a student of theology under the master Conrad of Speyer.”²⁹ This Conrad – more properly called Conrad of Hildesheim – had been trained as a master of theology in Paris, then served as *scholasticus* at the cathedral school in Mainz and dean of the canons in Speyer in the two decades prior to 1221.³⁰ According to Jordan, Caesar studied theology under this Conrad – whether in Paris itself or in one of these two German cities is not entirely clear. He then goes on to tell us that in a series of forceful sermons in Speyer, Caesar had “so angered the men and women” of the town by his ascetical demands that he had to be “spirited away” to safety “by his master Conrad,” at which point he then “returned” – the Latin term used is *reversus* – “to Paris.”³¹ Some time after these events, Caesar will have signed on to preach the Fifth Crusade,³² leaving the European mainland probably in the year 1218.³³

Now these Parisian connections are critical. Robert Lerner has recently brought to our attention the fact that the theology of Joachim of Fiore – and in particular his trinitarian conception of history – was

From the Profane to the Sacred”), I have also advanced the hypothesis that Caesar would later collaborate with Clare of Assisi in the composition of the latter’s *First Letter to Agnes of Prague* (1234).

²⁹*Chronica Fratris Jordani*, cc. 9 and 35, 7-8 and 34.

³⁰This Conrad was sent by Honorius III to preach to the German crusaders in the Holy Land in 1221 and was made bishop of Hildesheim in the same year, serving until 1246 when he resigned. He died in 1249. Cf. A. Bertram, *Geschichte des Bistums Hildesheim*, vol. I (Hildesheim: 1899), 226-245; J. Madey, “Konrad II. von Hildesheim,” *Biographisch-Bibliographisches Kirchenlexikon*, IV (1992): 392-393.

³¹*Chronica Fratris Jordani*, c. 9, 8 (“Sed per magistrum Conradum ereptus Parisius est reversus”).

³²Or at least that is the usual interpretation given to Jordan’s phrase “Et post sollempni facto passagio mare transiens” (ibidem). However, another possibility is that he actually went to the Holy Land to preach *against* the crusade! Indeed, this may help to explain the resonance he felt with the Franciscan preachers in the Levant.

³³In general, see T. C. Van Cleve, “The Fifth Crusade,” *A History of the Crusades*, Vol. II, eds. R.L. Wolff and H. W. Hazard (Madison, Wisconsin: University of Wisconsin Press, 1969), 377-428; and J. Powell, *Anatomy of a Crusade, 1213-1221* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1986). Caesar does not figure into Powell’s list of crusaders who took the vow to embark on the Fifth Crusade (Appendix II, 209-46).

already known in Paris among scholars possibly from as early as the late 1180s and certainly before 1196. For Peter the Chanter (d. 1197) had explicitly and scornfully referred to “*ille Joachim*” in his Commentary on the Book of Exodus, mocking Joachim’s predictive methodology of doing history.³⁴ Moreover, even though Joachim, like Bernard of Clairvaux, represented the older, more conservative monastic approach to theological matters (in contrast with the new scholasticism of the schools), he still was not without his adherents in Paris. Traces of his ideas can be found, for example, in men like Amalric of Bène and the Amaurians, condemned both in Paris in 1210 and at the Fourth Lateran Council of 1215.³⁵ Caesar’s presence in Paris – possibly during his first stint and certainly during his second – would surely have exposed him to these debates about Joachim swirling around the schools at this time and possibly even to some of his writings. The question for us then is this: did he have access to any of his writings and, if so, which ones? That is a question which, alas, no one has been able to answer with any surety thus far. However, it is not without interest that the section of the Latin manuscript of the Bibliothèque Nationale 11864 which contains within it several smaller works of the Calabrian abbot – including the earliest known copy of the *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus* – dates, according to Marjorie Reeves, from the first decade of the thirteenth century.³⁶

³⁴Robert E. Lerner, “Joachim and the Scholastics,” *Gioacchino da Fiore tra Bernardo di Clairvaux e Innocenzo III*, ed. R. Rusconi, Centro Internazionale di Studi Gioachimiti. Opere di Gioacchino da Fiore: testi e strumenti, 13 (Rome: Viella, 2001), 251–264. The author (252) notes that it is difficult to determine with any exactitude the precise dating of Peter the Chanter’s commentary on Exodus, running anywhere from the early 1180s (when he began his exegetical works) until his retirement in 1196 due to illness.

³⁵The Amaurians were condemned in proceedings against them in Paris in 1210. Robert of Courçon, the premier theologian in the curia at the time of their 1215 condemnation at Lateran IV, had been involved in these proceedings as a former Parisian Master. Cf. R. Lerner, “Joachim and the Scholastics,” 251 and 258).

³⁶M. Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Medieval Ages: A Study in Joachimism* (Notre Dame, University of Notre Dame Press, 1993 [1969]), 536 [1] (Appendix C). In a private communication, Jacques Dalarun, Director of the Institut de Recherche et d’Histoire des Textes, informed me that Dr. Patricia Stirnemann, expert in codicology at the same Institut, examined the BN manuscript 11864, reporting that it originated from the monastery of Corbie in northern France. She also observed that the text in question, the *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus*, had been added to the end of the original manuscript (f. 152v) by another hand of the early 13th century – thus confirming Reeves’ judgement. Given the northern provenance of the text, it is not at all

Joachim's Epistola universis Christi fidelibus

Given the environment in Paris, let us therefore conjecture that Caesar would have had at least some knowledge of Joachim's thought and possibly even of the writing in question, the *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus*. What can we say of this somewhat obscure little work? Though somewhat obscure to us – since modern scholars of the Calabrian abbot have concentrated their attention on his major works – the *Epistola* actually appears in quite a few manuscripts during the Middle Ages and was edited in 1937 by Jeanne Bignami-Odier from the Vatican Latin manuscript 3822.³⁷ In fact, the specific content of this *opuscula* will not be terribly important for our purposes here.³⁸ Suffice it to say that it is probably an early work in Joachim's output and a fairly generic call to the members of Christianity (*universis fidelibus*) to a conversion of life at the imminent approach of the last days. Moreover, Joachim makes this call through an impressive cascade of texts strung together from the reservoir of exhortations and warnings found in the prophetic and apocalyptic literature of the Bible, most especially the prophet Ezekiel.

What then might be the connection between Joachim's *epistola* and the *epistola* drawn up by Francis of Assisi and Caesar of Speyer in late 1220 or early 1221? An initial comparison of the two texts reveals that there are no direct textual citations from Joachim's letter found in the Franciscan letter; nor are there any significant thematic connections either – except, that is, one over-arching theme which would indeed have interested Francis. Joachim's *epistola*, for all its teeming biblical citations and warnings, is really, at root, a simple but clarion call for

inconceivable, though by no means certain, that Caesar could have had some familiarity with or knowledge of the text of Joachim's *epistola*.

³⁷J. Bignami-Odier, "Notes sur deux manuscrits de la bibliothèque du Vatican contenant des traités inédites de Joachim de Flore," *Mélanges d'archéologie et d'histoire* 54 (1937): 211-241 (the text is found at p 220-223). Madame Bignami-Odier refers to the text as a "lettre apocryphe . . . qui pourrait être la lettre-préface au pseudo-commentaire à Ézékiel" (220). Reeves (*Influence of Prophecy*, 536 [2]) dates this manuscript to the late thirteenth century and probably from southern Italy. The British scholar, however, lists the letter among the genuine works attributable to Joachim himself (cf. *Influence*, 42 and 517 [15] [Appendix A]). It is not without significance that the same manuscript also contains a pair of Joachim's Table of Concords lifted from the *Liber figurarum* – a datum to which I return shortly.

³⁸Hence, this article does not aim to present any kind of extended exegesis of the specific content of Joachim's letter. We are, in other words, still in need of a more searching examination of Joachim's rarely studied *epistola*.

Christian men and women, faced with the approaching last days, to *agere penitentiam* – to do penance: to change their way of living in order to come into conformity with the will of God before it is too late.³⁹ Given the orientation of Francis and the early friars as “penitents of Assisi,” this would obviously have caught Francis’s eye or at least his ear. But this is pretty slim evidence on which to base such bold claims to a linkage between the two documents! Fortunately, there is more – much more – tying these two texts together!

For, when urging his readers to a conversion of life, Joachim distinguishes three kinds of Christian people who are characterized by the three different ways in which they respond (or refuse to respond) to the word of the Lord. The critical passage reads as follows:

Lest anyone say that these times are not very clear and excuse oneself by a lack of understanding or some other difficulty, let that person know that all people found in the present world fall into three groups. The first are those who have fallen away from the faith, strangers to the Church’s sacraments and to every good deed. The second are those who “believe, but fall away in time of temptation” (Lk 8:13). “They profess that they know God, but they deny him by their deeds” (Ti 1:16). “They are glad when they have done evil and rejoice in the most wicked things” (Prov 2:14). The third are those whose faith and works are good, that is, those whom Almighty God foreknew would be such in belief and in deed. The first have been called “the scarlet multitude,” the second “Babylon,” the third “Jerusalem.”⁴⁰

³⁹Joachim uses the phrase (*agere penitentiam*) or a variant of the phrase at three different points in the piece, concluding the letter with the words: “Nunc ergo agite penitentiam et convertimini et vivetis ne quando rapiat ut leo animas vestras dum non est qui redimet neque qui salvum faciat” (223).

⁴⁰Bignami-Odier, 222: “. . . sed ne quis hec tempora minus perspicua esse dicat, et se de intellectu et difficultate excuset, noverit universos homines quos presens continet orbis tribus generibus descendisse. Primum genus est eorum qui sunt alieni a fide, peregrini a sacra . . . [missing] et omni opere pietatis. Secundum est eorum qui *credunt et in tempore temptationis recedunt*, qui *confitentur se nosse Deum, factis autem negant*, qui *letantur cum male fecerint et exultant in rebus pessimis*. Tercium est quorum fides et opera pia sunt, id est eorum quos omnipotens Deus fide et opere futuros esse prescivit. Et primi quidem multitudo coccinea dicta est, secundi Babylon, tercii Jerusalem. . . .” I use the English translation of Bernard McGinn (*Apocalyptic Spirituality*, The Classics of Western

This is the crucial text: the linchpin between the two *epistolae*. Note the tripartite division of the Christian Church presented by Joachim:

- First, those Christians who have rejected the sacraments and who, according to Joachim, consequently no longer do the good. Joachim seems to be referring to the Cathari heretics and possibly others who, though professing themselves to be good Christians, have in fact rejected one of the fundamental pillars of Catholic Christianity – the sacraments;
- Second, those Christians who want to believe and do the good but who, like those mentioned in the Parable of the Sower (Lk 8:5-18), having shallow roots, falter in times of temptation and allow themselves to be seduced by the things of the world; and
- Third, those who remain rooted in the heart of the Church, who stand steadfast in times of trial and whose faith finds expression in acts of goodness pleasing to God. These are those men and women who are already doing penance, whereas the first two groups have yet to do – and so are called to do – penance.

Joachim then associates these three groups of Christian people – or better, three different responses to this call to do penance – with three different biblical images: the first group is equated with “the scarlet multitude;”⁴¹ the second, “Babylon;” and the third, “Jerusalem.”

Francis, Caesar and the Epistola ad fideles

I would like to suggest that it is precisely this tripartite schema of three different groups – or three different responses to the call to do penance – that Caesar of Speyer brings to Francis’s attention when the latter decides, probably after his resignation, to address a message to the

Spirituality (New York: Paulist Press, 1979), 113-117, who notes (291, n.1) that he has filled in the missing portions and corrected Mme Bignami-Odier’s text based on Vat. Lat. 3822 with Milan, Bibl. Ambros. H. 15, inf., ff. 47-48.

⁴¹I have as yet been unable to identify to any degree of certainty an exact biblical allusion to this “scarlet multitude” (*multitudo coccinea*). The closest resonance I have been able to find is Is. 1:18 (“If your sins be as scarlet”) and Rev. 17:3 (the color of the beast on which the whore of Babylon rides).

whole Christian world with an urgent call to *facere penitentiam*.⁴² This letter – the longer version of the *Letter to the Faithful* – is addressed to three distinct groups within Christianity: religious, clerics and lay men and women.⁴³ But the connection between the two letters is not in equating the three groups addressed in Francis's letter with the three groups delineated by Joachim. Rather, Francis and Caesar structured the very core of their letter (vv. 4-62) on the basis of this same tripartite schema of Joachim's call to penance.

Actually, if we examine the longer version of the *Letter to the Faithful*, we will find the same three types of Christian responses to the call to penance that Joachim himself had distinguished in his letter: (1) those who have rejected or drifted away from the sacraments (vv. 4-24); (2) those who are called to do penance (vv. 25-47); and (3) those who are already doing penance (vv. 48-62). The following diagram lays out the structural parallels between the two letters:

⁴²The most famous instance of Francis's use of the phrase "to do penance" occurs in his *Testament* of 1226 where the phrase used is "*facere penitentiam*." However, prior to this time, the phrase which Francis and his friars used in the *Regula non bullata* is *agere penitentiam* in a variety of forms (e.g., "*agite penitentiam*," used in the context of preaching [RNB 21.3]; "*agat penitentiam*," used in the context of advice regarding the Clares [RNB 12,3]; and "*agere penitentiam*," used in the context of doing the will of God [RNB 23.7]. However, it is not without interest that each of these formulations appears to have been added to the Rule *after* 1220. Such language does not appear in the earliest layers of the *Regula non bullata*.

⁴³The opening of the text of the longer version reads: "*Universis christianis religiosis, clericis et laicis, masculis et feminis, omnibus qui habitant in universo mundo . . .*" (Esser, *Opuscula*, 207). Given the lack of commas in medieval latin, the translation of this phrase is, of course, open to interpretation. The editors of *Francis of Assisi: Early Documents*, for example, opt for the following: ". . . to all Christian religious people, clergy and laity, men and women. . ." (45). I find this translation needlessly confusing. It seems to me that Francis is simply addressing three classic divisions of medieval society: religious, clergy and the laity who are male and female. Choosing to translate the word "*religiosis*" as an adjective rather than a noun tends to obfuscate the fact that the letter does indeed address religious (and most particularly the Friars Minor). One will find Francis using the very same themes when addressing the friars in other texts of the *opuscula*.

Text of Joachim's <i>Epistola</i>	Three Biblical Allusions	Précis of Francis' <i>Epistola</i>
I.		I.
"The first are those who have fallen away from the faith, strangers to the Church's sacraments and to every good deed";	"The scarlet multitude"	vv. 4-24 Short theological exposé on eucharist and penance;
II.		II.
"The second are those who ' <i>believe, but fall away in time of temptation</i> ' (Lk 8:13). ' <i>They profess that they know God, but they deny him by their deeds</i> ' (Ti 1:16). ' <i>They are glad when they have done evil and rejoice in the most wicked things</i> ' (Prov 2:14)";	"Babylon"	vv. 25-47 The call for all Christians to do penance;
III.		III.
"The third are those whose faith and works are good, that is, those whom Almighty God fore-knew would be such in belief and in deed."	"Jerusalem"	vv. 48-62 In praise of those who are already doing penance.

Perhaps a closer examination of the structure of the content of this letter might be even more helpful.

The letter begins with a greeting and a few introductory words of a personal nature by Francis himself (vv. 1-3). There then follows the

core content of the letter, based on Joachim's tripartite schema, as illustrated below.

(1) Verses 5-24 = Joachim's first group. First, those who have rejected or are wavering with respect to the sacrament of the Eucharist are given a short theological treatise on the connection between the Word of God the Father, the Incarnation of that Word in the womb of the Virgin and the presence of the Word-made-flesh in the Eucharistic mystery. This is followed by a short section urging the reception of the sacraments of Penance and Eucharist. We are, of course, accustomed to reading these words as Francis's personal response to the call of Lateran IV urging a more active Christian participation in and respect for the Eucharist. The conciliar call is surely in the background. However, it is my contention that, given the elevated theological language and the way the biblical citations are used in verses 4-24, this section represents a brief theological nugget primarily written not by Francis but by Caesar of Speyer, laying out the foundations of Catholic belief and practice regarding Penance and Eucharist.⁴⁴ Indeed, I believe it to be one of three unique contributions made by Caesar to this letter.⁴⁵

⁴⁴It is quite possible – but difficult at this stage to determine with any precision – that Francis might have contributed in some manner to the content of the latter part of this section (verses 14-24). Some of the phrases here will indeed be redolent of language used in other texts dating from this same period (e.g., RNB 22 and the shorter version of the EpFid). That, in itself, is not necessarily definitive proof of Francis's authorship since, as I have contended, Caesar will have had a hand, either directly or indirectly, in shaping these same texts. More curious is the fact that the specific formulation used in v. 22, employing the latin verb *debemus*, introduces a series of no less than ten such exhortatory statements urging the reader to do specific types of behavior. Is this then a more proper dividing line between the two sections than the one I am proposing based on Joachim's letter? I think not. The first such exhortation in verse 22 urges the reception of the sacraments of penance and Eucharist; the rest – the other nine – all incite the reader to perform actions of a non-sacramental nature. In other words, if the dividing line between the two sections is to be marked thematically (sacramental belief and practice vs. the call to a penitential lifestyle) rather than linguistically (the exhortation to ten actions by means of the *debemus* formulation), then one would be correct in asserting that the seam between the sections could be more properly located between vv. 24 and 25 rather than between vv. 21 and 22. On the other hand, a different case could be made in favor of v. 14 (rather than v. 25) as being the dividing line between sections I and II. In this instance, although still more or less thematically linked to the issue of sacramental belief and practice, the tone in these verses becomes more exhortatory and could be conceivably construed as part of the call to do penance. Indeed, in favor of this possibility, it may not be without significance that while the beginning of the shorter version of the *Epistola ad fideles* cites a number of lines (vv. 18, 37, 22, 25 and 48) from what I have called parts I, II and III of the longer version,

(2) Verses 25-47 = Joachim's second group. Then follows a section calling on all members of Christian society to do penance. It starts out, in verse 25, with a short and simple phrase so typical of Francis – “Let them produce ‘*fruits worthy of penance*’ [Lk 3.8].”⁴⁶ This is followed by a series of staccato phrases punctuated repeatedly by the subjunctive – “and let them” do this and “let them” do that – spelling out concretely what it means for a follower of Christ to *facere penitentiam*. The people addressed are all those who, like in the parable of the Sower from the Gospel of Luke, have been tempted to fall away in times of temptation and trial or have been seduced by an attraction to the things of this world.⁴⁷ Francis is now calling such people to change their way of life – “to do penance”; and

(3) Verses 48-62 = Joachim's third group. Finally, there is a paean of praise for those who are already doing penance and who, as a result, are indeed pleasing in the sight of God by virtue of their holy lives.

This is the core of the long version of the *Letter to the Faithful* based on the call for all Christians to do penance. To this core, based on the tripartite structure of Joachim's call to the Christians of his day, have been added a short introductory greeting (vv. 1-3) and a simple concluding farewell (vv. 86-88). However, between the tripartite core and this farewell, it would appear that a lengthy *exemplum* – describing in colorful and concrete detail the fate of one who refuses to do penance – has also been inserted into the text as we have it. I would conjecture that this *exemplum* has probably been tacked on or added as a preacher's

not a single citation has been taken from vv. 4-13 (Part I). Again, it is important to stress that the case I am presenting at this stage is quite hypothetical in nature. Wherever the exact dividing line between sections I and II might eventually be determined to be, it does not seem to vitiate the overall structural influence that Joachim's letter would have had upon the minorite letter.

⁴⁵The other two contributions will be the two different biblical citations at the end of the third section of the core (vv. 57c – 60 and vv. 61-62). Both of these citations will be discussed more at length in the last part of this presentation.

⁴⁶EpFidII, v. 25: “Faciamus insuper ‘*fructos dignos poenitentiae*’” [Lk 3.8].

⁴⁷Indeed, it is not without significance that the parable of the Sower will be cited in full in the *Regula non bullata*, ch. 22 – one of the texts added to the Rule, I would contend, by Caesar prior to his departure for Germany.

aid for the use of those friars going out to announce the same call of penance that is contained within the core of the letter itself.

Further Connections between the Two Letters

The parallel between the three different responses to the word of the Lord in these two *epistolae* should now be fairly evident. But there is even more evidence of a connection between the two documents.

Recall that Joachim associated the three different types of Christian responses to the call to do penance with three different groups bearing titles of biblical resonance. If the parallel between the Calabrian and Franciscan letters holds true, then the first group addressed in the *Epistola ad fideles* struggling with or rejecting the Catholic sacraments would be equivalent to the “scarlet multitude”; the second group explicitly called and needing to do penance (since still living in sin) would be equivalent, quite naturally, to “Babylon”; and the third group already doing penance and living in accord with the will of God would be associated with “Jerusalem.”

The New Jerusalem as the *novum monasterium*

Now it is indeed fascinating that this symbol of Jerusalem – not the historical city of Jerusalem but the symbol of the new and eternal Jerusalem – occupies a special place in Joachim’s apocalyptic view of salvation history. This “new Jerusalem” represents not only the state of existence of saved humanity after the cessation of history (i.e., the life of the blessed in heaven gathered around the throne of the Lamb). It is also the state of those men and women who, as the second Age of the Son begins to elide into and be overtaken by the third Age of the Spirit, are said to be living fully “in the Spirit.”⁴⁸ Moreover, those who are

⁴⁸The literature on Joachim and his apocalyptic system is extraordinarily vast. Suffice it to cite here only a few select works which deal specifically with the passing of the Second Age of the Son into the Third Age of the Spirit: Delno C. West and Sandra Zimdars-Swartz, *Joachim of Fiore: A Study in Spiritual Perception and History* (Bloomington, Indiana: University of Indiana Press, 1983), 10-29; E. Pásztor, “Ideale del monachesimo ed ‘età dello Spirito’ come realtà spirituale e forma d’utopia,” *L’età dello Spirito e la fine dei tempi in Gioacchino da Fiore e nel gioachimismo medievale*. Atti del II Congresso internazionale di studi gioachimiti (6-9 settembre 1984), ed. A. Crocco (S. Giovanni in Fiore: Centro Internazionale di Studi Gioachimiti, 1986), 55-124; and S. E. Wessley,

living fully in the Spirit are precisely those who indeed have done penance, having brought themselves by their choices and actions into full conformity with the will of God. Hence, the new Jerusalem is the state of those who have done penance, are doing penance and are now living in penance, "on earth as it is in heaven." This is the Kingdom of God come to its fullness in human history. As such, they join, as it were, the chorus of those giving praise to God around the throne of the Lamb.

Now Joachim conceptualizes this new Jerusalem as a kind of *novum monasterium*. This new monastery of the Third Age has been famously depicted in *figura XII* of the *Liber figurarum* as the *dispensatio novi ordinis pertinens ad tertium statum* (see Plate 1). Whether or not these *figurae* are directly attributable to Joachim himself (drawn up as a final and extended statement of concepts already found elsewhere in his writings) or to his disciples in the years shortly after his death is still a matter of some debate.⁴⁹ However, what is significant for us here is that the new Jerusalem – this new monastery – is depicted as being composed of seven oratories: a central oratory (where the *pater spiritualis* resides), surrounded by four other oratories (peopled by religious marked by certain distinguishing virtues) with two more oratories attached

Joachim of Fiore and Monastic Reform. American University Studies, Series VII, Theology and Religion, 72 (New York: Peter Lang, 1990), 61-80.

⁴⁹The scholarly debate turns on whether the *figurae* as we have them in various forms can definitively be traced back to Joachim himself or to his Florentian community in the first decades after his death. On these issues, see: M. Reeves and B. Hirsch-Reich, *The figurae of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972); E. Pásztor, "Ideale del monachesimo ed età dello Spirito," spec. 110-123; F. Troncarelli, "Il *Liber figurarum*: osservazioni ed ipotesi," *Roma, magister mundi: itineraria culturale medievalis. Mélanges offerts au Père L.E. Boyle à l'occasion de son 75e anniversaire*, ed. J. Hamesse, Textes et Études du Moyen Age, 10/2 (Louvain-la-Neuve: Fédération Internationale des Instituts d'Études du Moyen Age, 1998), 927-949; idem, "Il *Liber figurarum* tra 'gioachimiti' e 'gioachimisti,'" *Gioacchino da Fiore tra Bernardo di Clairvaux e Innocenzo III* (Rome: Viella, 2001), 267-287; and most recently and succinctly, idem, *Gioacchino da Fiore: la vita, il pensiero, le opere* (Rome: Citta Nuova, 2002), 44-47. Thus Antonio Crocco's remarks of 1976 in *Gioacchino da Fiore e il gioachimismo*, 2nd ed. (Naples: Liguori, 1976), 27, n. 1, were perhaps a bit too definitive: "È da lamantare però che il Russo, in polemica col Tondelli, classificò ancora tra le 'opere dubbie' di Gioacchino il *Liber Figurarum*, la cui autenticità, soprattutto dopo la scoperta del nuovo Codice di Oxford, deve considerarsi immune da ogni dubbio". Whether the creation of the *figurae* can be attributed directly to Joachim or to the first generation of his disciples, what is important for us is that they would have been known at least in some form in the first decades of the thirteenth century. Recall that the manuscript BN 11864 from Corbie monastery containing a copy of the *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus* also contained the Table of Concords from the *Liber figurarum*.

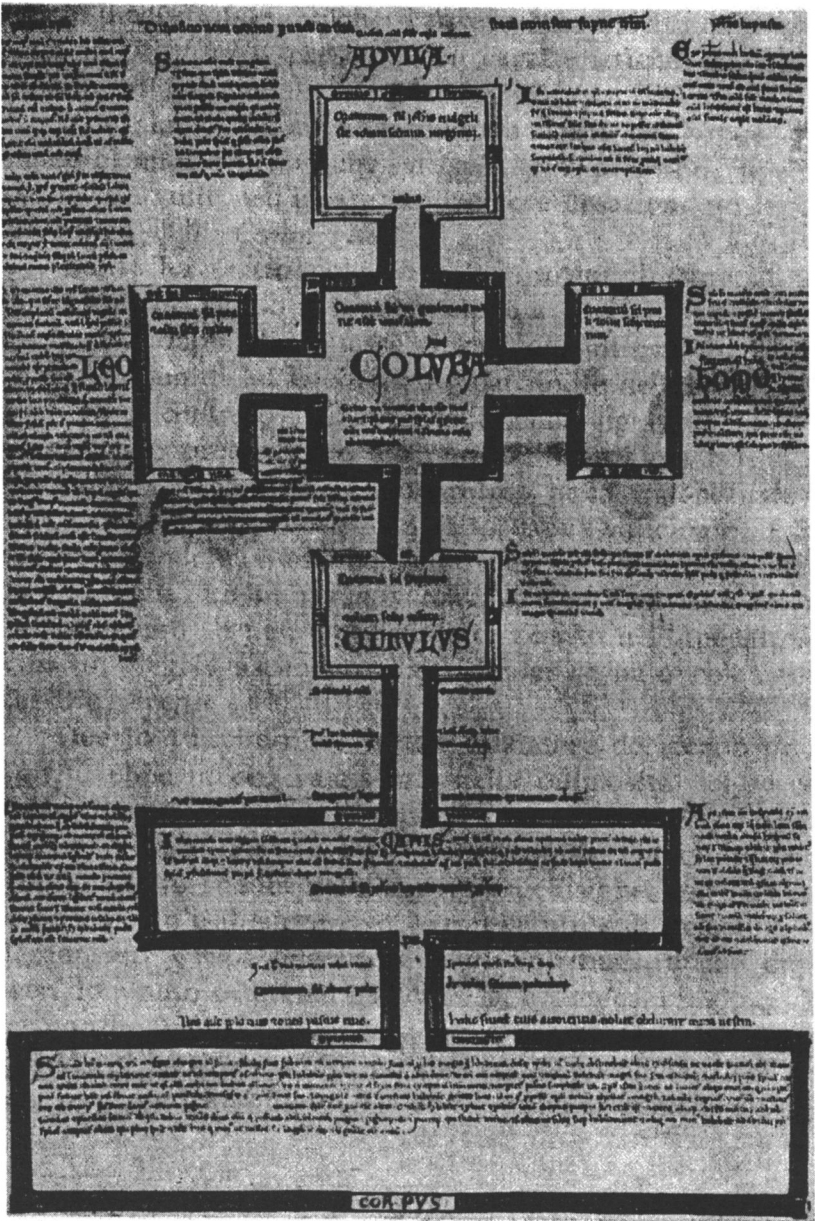


PLATE I: The *novum monasterium* as depicted in the *Dispensatio novi ordinis pertinens ad tertium statum* (full view), taken from Codex Reggio Emilia, Bibl. Semin., R¹.

beneath them. The whole structure resembles a Greek cross with a base (the sixth and seventh oratories) and is meant to mirror the throne of the Lamb surrounded by the four living creatures and myriads of the just. Critical are these sixth and seventh oratories, placed at a small distance from the core of the monastery *yet still within its walls* (see Plate 2 below). These latter oratories are peopled not by monks – like the other four oratories – but by clergy (the *ordo continentium* in the sixth oratory) and by lay men and women (the *ordo conjugatorum* in the seventh oratory) who have heard the call to do penance and who are also said to be living, even now, at the end of the Second Age of the Son in the Spirit-filled existence of the Third Age.⁵⁰ The members of this *novum monasterium* – religious, clergy and laity of Spirit-filled life – are therefore the prototypes of the heavenly court of the Lamb as depicted in several scenes of the Book of Revelation.

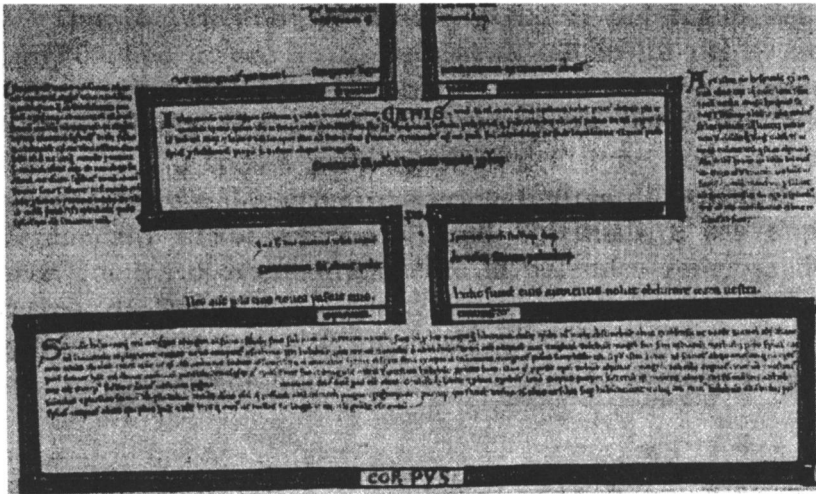


PLATE 2: The sixth and seventh oratories in the *novum monasterium* of the *Dispensatio novi ordinis* (detail). Notice that both of these oratories are located *within* – and not outside of – the “monastery” which is the Church of the New Jerusalem.

⁵⁰A radically different interpretation of the *novum monasterium* has been presented by A. Thompson, “A Reinterpretation of Joachim of Fiore’s *Dispositio novi ordinis* from the *Liber figurarum*,” *Cîteaux* 33 (1982): 195-205

The New Jerusalem as the Heavenly Court

It is not at all coincidental that these three groups are the very same addressees of the Franciscan *Letter to the Faithful*: viz., the religious, clergy and laity. Caesar, I believe, was aware of this image and of its ramifications for a vision of a Church living fully in the Spirit and he deployed all his skill to bring that vision to bear on Francis's letter *universis christianis*. He does so in the third section of the core (vv. 48-62). This new Jerusalem, composed of those who are *even now* doing penance, is depicted as those who are pleasing in the sight of God and, as such, find themselves praised by his Son. Indeed, the meaning of this section of the letter sometimes eludes commentators precisely because its purpose is not readily grasped. For after noting how the Spirit makes its home and dwelling place⁵¹ within those men and women who persevere in doing works worthy of penance – actions which make of them “spouses,” “brothers” and “mothers” of Jesus Christ and He of them (vv. 51-56a), Caesar then concludes this third part of the core by having Christ give praise to God and bless such true and faithful disciples. And he does this by means of several carefully selected and important scriptural citations.

First, in an adaptation of Jesus' final prayer for his disciples in John 17, Caesar (and Francis) have Christ praying for those who have accepted his words, have produced “fruits worthy of penance” and who can truly as a result now be called his disciples.⁵² Their prayer for them is that they see his glory one day in the heavenly kingdom and

⁵¹The scriptural allusion is, of course, to Jn 14:23. However, what is the *novum monasterium* if not also a “*habituaculum et mansio*” (EpFidII, v. 49) where the Spirit now makes its dwelling? To dwell in the *novum monasterium* is to have God make his dwelling within oneself.

⁵²This farewell discourse of Christ to his disciples in Jn 17 also plays a key role in RNB 22, vv. 42-55 which was written, I have contended, after Francis returned from Egypt in 1220 and quite possibly mirroring Francis's own farewell discourse to the friars upon his resignation in September, 1220. But the purpose of both citations is the same: to praise those who have, as in the Parable of the Sower, welcomed the word of God, allowed it to take root and have as a result produced “fruits worthy of penance.” Moreover, it is intriguing that when, in c. 31 of the *Sacrum commercium*, Jesus is preparing to leave his disciples and return to the Father, Caesar, instead of citing the Jn 17 discourse (as one would have expected), has Jesus suddenly quote seven admonitions from the Gospels. As I have argued elsewhere (cf. M. Cusato, “Talking about Ourselves,” 46-48), Caesar's purpose in the SC is quite different and is meant to intentionally startle the reader by *not* quoting the rest of Jn 17.

experience the life of God himself. But, our authors assert, this prayer is being answered *in the present age* in those men and women who are doing penance and who have brought their lives into conformity with the will of God. Finally, our authors give testimony to this as they conclude this section of the core – indeed the core of the letter itself – with a prayer for all human beings to fulfill their highest calling and their deepest destiny by the integrity of their lives:

Let every creature
in heaven, on earth, in the sea and in the depths,
give praise, glory, honor and blessing
to Him who suffered so much,
Who has given and will give in the future every good,
for He is our power and strength . . .⁵³

This seemingly innocuous prayer, crafted from the familiar language of liturgical prayer, is in fact none other than a combination of images drawn from two scenes in the Book of Revelation (Rev 4:9 and 5:12-13) that depict the heavenly court gathered in continuous and joyous praise around the throne of the Lamb who was slain.⁵⁴ Thus, once again, the authors of the *Epistola ad fideles* are making the astonishing assertion that those who are doing penance not only participate in but actually constitute the inbreaking Third Age of the Spirit and thus, by that very fact, are *even now* part of the heavenly court whose works and lives give praise to God and the Lamb. Indeed, this same theme will be even more dramatically presented in that grand scene of the universal church – with its multiple ranks and vocations and functions – found in chapter 23 of the *Regula non bullata*.⁵⁵ In the vision

⁵³EpFidII: “Ei autem qui tanta sustinuit pro nobis, tot bona contulit et conferet in futurum, *omnis creatura*, quae est *in caelis, in terra, in mari* et in abyssis reddat laudem, *gloriam, honorem et benedictionem*. . . .”

⁵⁴Esser – and the editors of *Francis of Assisi: Early Documents* – both missed the reference to Rev. 4:9.

⁵⁵RNB 23, vv. 4 and espec. 7: “Et gratias agimus tibi, quia ipse Filius tuus venturus est in gloria maiestatis suae mittere maledictos, **qui poenitentiam non egerunt** et te non cognoverunt, in ignem aeternum, et dicere omnibus, qui te cognoverunt et adoraverunt et tibi **servierunt in poenitentia**: ‘*Venite, benedicti Patris mei*, percipite *regnum*, quod *vobis paratum* est ab origine *mundi*’ (cf. Mt. 25:34). . . .Et Domino Deo universos intra sanctam ecclesiam catholicam et apostolicam servire volentes et omnes sequentes ordines: sacerdotes, diaconos, subdiaconos, acolythos, exorcistas, lectores, ostiarios et omnes

of Francis and Caesar, therefore, those who do penance comprise the inbreaking new *ordo* of the Third Status; they *are* the new Jerusalem.

Recapitulation

Francis of Assisi went to the Holy Land and Egypt in the summer of 1219 to express his opposition to the Fifth Crusade and to try to convince the Christian crusaders to abandon the path of further bloodshed and division of the human fraternity. While in the Levant, he made the acquaintance of a new recruit to the Order whom Elias of Cortona, minister of the province of Syria, had recently brought into the fraternity through his preaching: Caesar of Speyer. It seems that this Caesar, a preacher of some repute, will either have been converted to a different approach to events in the Holy Land – a minorite approach – or, more likely, he will have discovered a real resonance between his own ideals and those of the Friars Minor as presented by Brother Elias. That approach consisted in the belief that God did not want his creatures to resolve the difficult problems of human existence through further bloodshed but rather through more peaceful means and dialogue in the manner of the non-violent Jesus, respectful of their common and sacred creaturehood. The rectitude of Caesar's choice to enter the fraternity could only have been reinforced and strengthened by his encounter with the one who stood at the center of this vision of life: Francis of Assisi. With both men in the Holy Land opposed to the policy adopted by the leaders of the Christian forces, it seems likely that Caesar would have pointed out to Francis the common ground between

clericos, universos religiosos et religiosas, omnes conversos [pueros?] et parvulos, pauperes et egenos, reges et principes, laboratores et agricolas, servos et dominos, omnes virgines et continentes et maritatas, laicos, masculos et feminas, omnes infantes, adolescentes, iuvenes et senes, sanos et infirmos, omnes pusillos et magnos, et omnes populos, gentes, tribus et linguas (cf. Rev 7:9), omnes nationes et omnes homines ubicumque terrarum, qui sunt et erunt, humiliter rogamus et supplicamus nos omnes fratres minores, *servi inutilis* (Lk 17:10), ut omnes in vera fide et **poenitentia perseveremus**, quia aliter nullus salvari potest." Esser (and the editors of *Early Documents*) cite the allusion to those standing before the throne of the Lamb in Rev 7:9 ("ex omnibus gentibus, et tribubus, et populis, et linguis") but miss a similar allusion to Rev 5:9 ("ex omni tribu, et lingua, et populo, et natione"). Another missed allusion in verse 7 ("omnes pusillos et magnos") is to Rev 19:4-5: "Et ceciderunt seniores viginti quatuor, et quatuor animalia, et adoraverunt Deum sedentem super thronum, dicentes: Amen: Alleluia. Et vox de throno exivit, dicens: Laudem dicite Deo nostro omnes servi eius: et qui timetis eum pusilli et magni."

his own vision and the opposition to the crusading movement (albeit for different reasons)⁵⁶ expressed by the famous abbot of San Giovanni, Joachim of Fiore, whose ideas may have had a formative influence upon the German preacher while in Paris. For, according to Joachim, prior to the Last Days the non-believer was to be converted not by those wielding the sword but by those preaching in apostolic poverty.

Forced by events within the Order to return to Italy, ill and overcome by the daunting task of regaining control of an Order drifting away from its original ideals, Francis resigned at the Emergency Chapter of September 1220. Nonetheless, he did attempt to maintain an influence upon the friars and the world around him through the written word. And the first word he will have written, now helped by the Paris-formed Caesar of Speyer, was a letter whose intention was to call all Christian men and women, including those attached to his own movement, to *agere penitentiam*. To accomplish this task, Caesar will have introduced Francis to a letter written by the same Joachim about which he must have had some knowledge while studying in Paris: the *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus*. Borrowing the tripartite structure employed in Joachim's letter, Francis and his co-author Caesar will have composed a text in late 1220 or early 1221 that later will come to be known as the *Epistola ad fideles*, calling the men and women of their time to return to the sacramental life of the Church and produce actions worthy of penance. These members of Christian society, already doing penance, are likened to the new and eternal Jerusalem of Scripture because their very lives give praise to God. Friars would then have been sent out with copies of this letter to preach the message of penance, having inserted into the text an *exemplum* which was to be used to illustrate their message.

Some Conclusions

On the basis of this brief analysis of the structure and content of the Franciscan *Epistola ad fideles*, allow me to lay out four conclusions.

⁵⁶Joachim's opposition to the crusade was primarily based on exegetical grounds, as demonstrated, among others, by E. Randolph Daniel, "Apocalyptic Conversion: the Joachimite Alternative," *Traditio* 25 (1969): 127-154.

(1) When Francis decided to send a letter to all Christians (*universis christianis*) after his resignation, the magisterial document that he composed with the help of Caesar of Speyer was based on and structured on the call to penance announced in a previous letter *universis Christi fidelibus* written by Joachim of Fiore. Given that the similarities between the two letters are based on a rather simple tripartite structure and general message of doing penance rather than on any direct textual borrowings, it is quite possible, even probable, that the Franciscan authors did not have the text of Joachim's letter in hand. The ideas probably came to Francis directly from Caesar himself.

(2) The use of the eschatological scenario of the new Jerusalem of the Third Age of the Spirit would seem to herald the very first instance and introduction of apocalyptic thinking into minorite consciousness and writing. However, at this initial stage the *novus ordo* was not in any way construed as referring directly to the Franciscan fraternity but rather to all those in the universal Church – religious, clerics and laity – who embraced the call to penance. It is only later, with the appearance of the *Expositio super Hieremiam* in the early 1240s, that the Friars Minor will begin to identify themselves as one of the *duo ordines* which Joachim predicted would herald the passage from the Second to the Third Status.⁵⁷

(3) Although it might appear impertinent to assert it, it is quite conceivable that the trinitarian language used by Francis from this point forward in his writings – one will not find it very clearly at all prior to this in the evolving layers of the *Regula non bullata* – might be attributable not to any kind of high (johannine) christology on the part of Francis but rather to his exposure through Caesar to the significance of the Trinity in Joachim of Fiore's theology of history. Indeed, if Francis would have been pleased to hear of Joachim's opposition to the crusading ideal and esteemed him well enough to use the structure of

⁵⁷On this critical text, see: F. Simoni, "Il *Super Hieremiam* e il gioachimismo francescano," *Bullettino dell'Istituto storico italiano per il Medio Evo* 82 (1970): 62-93; S. Wessley, "Terra Incognita: The *Commentary on Jeremiah*," in ibidem, *Joachim of Fiore and Monastic Reform* (New York: Peter Lang, 1990), 101-135; V. De Fraja, "Usi politici della profezia gioachimita," *Annali dell'Istituto storico italo-germanico in Trento* 25 (1999): 375-400; and M. Kaup, "Friedrich II. und die Joachiten: Zur frühen joachitischen Antichristologie," ibidem, 401-416. I have also discussed the Franciscan connection to this text in an unpublished presentation, "Between a Rock and a Hard Place: The Franciscan Glosses on the Pseudo-Joachim Commentary *Super Hieremiam*" given at the 36th International Congress on Medieval Studies (Kalamazoo, Michigan: May, 2001).

his *Epistola universis Christi fidelibus* as the structural framework for his own *Epistola ad fideles*, then it becomes more plausible to wonder whether the sudden appearance henceforth in Francis's writings of trinitarian motifs could very well be due to the new-found if generalized influence of the Calabrian abbot on his own thought.⁵⁸

(4) If what I have posited above as a hypothetical reconstruction is fairly accurate, then the so-called shorter version of the *Letter to the Faithful* must postdate this longer version and, indeed, has been distilled directly from it. Since no longer addressed to *universis christianis* but to one segment of that broader community of faithful – lay penitents gathering around the minorite movement – one can expect that the tripartite structural frame drawn from Joachim will no longer be readily discernible. Indeed, it now has a simplified binary structure: *De illis qui faciunt poenitentiam* and *De illis qui non agunt poenitentiam*; and its vivid *exemplum* for preaching has been trimmed of its most colorful details and truncated to express only its principal moral lesson.⁵⁹ Why was this second version written? My sense is that, after 1220, as individual men and women in the cities of central and northern Italy began to coalesce into groups of devout Christians desiring to do penance in the manner of Francis and his friars, Cardinal Ugolino dei Segni – much as he had done for the Poor Ladies in 1219⁶⁰ – took it upon himself to bring a

⁵⁸It is sometimes asserted that a positive reception of Joachim's ideas would have been virtually unthinkable given the disfavor that the abbot's reputation had suffered since the condemnation of his approach to the Trinity at Lateran IV in 1215 (canon 1). However, it should be recalled that on 27 December 1220, Honorius III wrote a letter in defense of Joachim's orthodoxy and the integrity of the Order which he had established (cf. Italian translation of this bull in F. Troncarelli, *Gioacchino da Fiore: la vita, il pensiero, le opere* (Rome: Città Nuova, 2002), 87-88 (with reference to the original Latin text).

⁵⁹A comprehensive, line-by-line comparison of the two letters is needed and would be helpful to show exactly how the shorter version was distilled from the longer version. Indeed, virtually every single line in the short version (with certain grammatical changes being made to scriptural citations used in the original to accommodate the audience of the shorter letter and the addition of a few select words here and there) can be accounted for in the longer version, except two found at the very conclusion of the letter: "Et qui nesciunt legere, saepe legere faciant" [EpFidI, v. 20] – an understandable addition, especially given the lay audience of the text; and "Et qui hoc non fecerint, tenebuntur reddere *rationem* in die iudicii (cf. Mt. 12:36) *ante tribunal* Domini nostri Jesu Christi (cf. Rm. 14:10)" [EpFidI, v. 22].

⁶⁰For an overview of these matters, see, for example, M. Bartoli, *Chiara d'Assisi*, Bibliotheca Seraphica Capuccina, 37 (Rome: Istituto Storico dei Cappuccini, 1989), 107-112; M.P. Alberzoni, *La nascita di un istituzione. L'Ordine di S. Damiano nel XIII secolo* (Milan: CUSL, 1996), 17-20; eadem, "Papato e nuovi Ordini religiosi femminili," *Il papato*

greater sense of organization to their lives by drafting a form of life appropriate to their status as lay Christians. This document is the *Memoriale propositi* of 1221. However, much like the Ugolino *forma vitae* drawn up for Clare's burgeoning movement, this document also had no recognizable "Franciscan" content or imprint. Recognizing this, Francis will have redacted a second letter, distilled from the recently completed letter to religious, clergy and laity, that would now offer to these groups of lay penitents associated with the Franciscan movement a truly minorite word for their lives. Hugolino's document had not done so; Francis's short letter now did.⁶¹

However, with those changes having been made, the joachite structure and background to the original letter would quickly be lost and forgotten – that is, until today!

The Franciscan Institute
St. Bonaventure, NY

MICHAEL F. CUSATO, O.F.M.

duecentesco e gli ordini mendicanti. Atti del XXV convegno internazionale (Assisi, febbraio 1998). Atti dei convegni della Società internazionale di studi francescani e del Centro interuniversitario di studi francescani. NS, 8 (Spoleto: Centro Italiano di studi sull'Alto Medioevo, 1998), 228-234, and most recently eadem, "Le congregazioni monastiche: le Damianite," *Dove va la storiografia monastica in Europa? Temi e metodi di ricerca per lo studio della vita monastica e regolare in età medievale alle soglie del terzo millennio*, ed. G. Andenna (Milan: Vita e Pensiero, 2001), 390-394.

⁶¹Indeed, given the changes to both the structure and purpose of this shorter version of the original *Epistola ad fideles*, it would no longer be appropriate to continue to refer to the shorter text as an "*epistola ad fideles*." Although textually still linked to the original text, it has in effect become a very different document. Thus, I think the more descriptive subtitle chosen by the Esser and the editors of the *Early Documents* project is more accurate and should henceforth be used as its actual title: viz. "*Exhortatio ad fratres et sorores de poenitentia*."